OpenClaw TUI Interaction

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1. Course Content

Course Overview

OpenClaw TUI (Terminal User Interface) is a terminal-based text interaction interface. No graphical desktop environment is required; you can chat with the OpenClaw robot directly from the command line. TUI interaction is especially suitable for scenarios where you connect to the robot remotely via SSH and perform pure text interaction in the terminal.

Learning Objectives

- Master the method to start a terminal interaction session using the `openclaw tui` command
- Learn the advanced usage of starting TUI with parameters
- Become familiar with common conversation commands (slash commands) in the TUI terminal
- Be able to troubleshoot and resolve common errors during TUI usage

2. Starting TUI Conversation

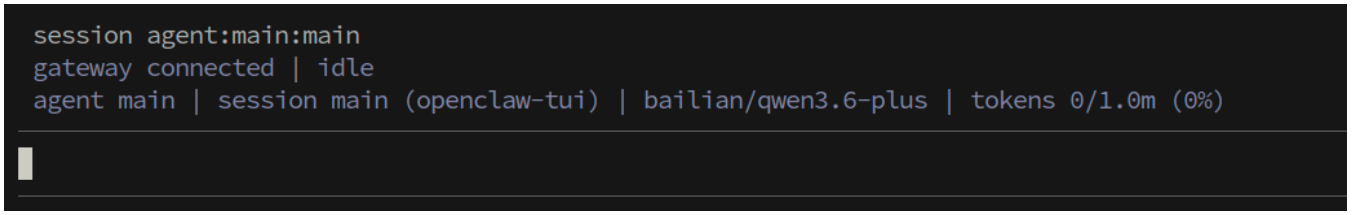
Applicable Scenarios

TUI conversation is mainly applicable to the following scenarios:

- **SSH Remote Connection** — After logging into the robot remotely via SSH, you can directly chat with OpenClaw in the terminal
- **Lightweight Interaction** — Compared to Web UI, TUI consumes fewer resources and starts faster, making it suitable for quick debugging and daily use

Enter the following command directly in the terminal to start the TUI conversation interface:

```
openclaw tui
```



> **Note**
>
> - You can chat with the robot by typing text just like in WebChat
> - As long as the session ID is the same, the dialogue history is synchronized between WebChat and TUI

3. Common TUI Terminal Conversation Commands

- Conversation commands in the TUI terminal are exactly the same as slash commands in WebChat, with identical usage. All commands must start with `/` and be sent as **independent messages**



4. Common Errors and Solutions

4.1 Invalid API

Symptoms: After sending a message, the robot reports an invalid API-KEY, authentication failure, or returns a 401 error.

Possible causes and solutions:

- **API-KEY configuration error** — Check whether the API-KEY configuration item in `openclaw.json` is correct; reconfigure and restart the gateway
- **API-KEY expired** — Go to the model service provider's platform to check whether the API-KEY has expired; generate a new KEY and update the configuration
- **Model service provider address error** — Confirm that the API address (base URL) for the model in `openclaw models list` is filled in correctly

```
# View current model configuration
openclaw models list
# View model status
openclaw models status
```

4.2 Model Quota Exceeded

Symptoms: After sending a message, it reports that the model's call quota limit has been reached (Rate Limit / Quota Exceeded), or returns a 429 status code.

Possible causes and solutions:

- **Quota exhausted** — Model service providers impose daily/hourly call limits or token limits on free/trial accounts; please check your account quota status
- **Multiple concurrent sessions consuming quota** — Having multiple sessions open for parallel conversations will accelerate quota consumption; it is recommended to reduce the number of concurrent sessions
- **Switch model** — If the current model's quota is limited, you can use the `/model` command to switch to another configured model to continue the conversation

4.3 Gateway Not Running

Symptoms: After running `openclaw tui`, it reports that it cannot connect to the Gateway, the connection is refused, or it hangs in the connecting state for a long time.

Possible causes and solutions:

- **Gateway not started** — Start the Gateway service first:

```
openclaw gateway start
# Or use foreground run mode
openclaw gateway run
```

- **Gateway stopped or crashed** — Check the Gateway running status and restart:

```
openclaw gateway status
openclaw gateway restart
```

- **Port occupied** — The Gateway's default port is occupied by another program; check the port usage:

```
# Check whether the default port 18789 is occupied
lsof -i :18789
```

4.4 Session Abnormal or Frozen

Symptoms: The TUI interface is unresponsive, no reply for a long time after sending a message, or the interface displays abnormally.

Possible causes and solutions:

- **Model response timeout** — Use the `/stop` command to stop the currently generating response, then send the message again
- **Terminal window size issue** — Resize the terminal window and run the command again; some terminal windows that are too small may cause display anomalies
- **Session context too long** — Use `/compact` to compact the conversation context and free up token

space

- **Restart TUI** — Press `Ctrl+C` to exit TUI, then run `openclaw tui` again to start it